

Promoting workplace safety in research on workers' unsafe behaviours in Iran

Background/Objectives

Accidents and injuries have been a regular occurrence in the petrochemical industries, because of the particular conditions dependent on its nature, over the last decade. Major occupational accidents that occur in this industry frequently result in significant financial and social losses. In this context, workers' unsafe behaviours are the main causes of work-related accidents and injuries. The first step to promote safe behaviours and reduce accidents and losses in petrochemical industries is identification of the influencing factors associated with workers' unsafe behaviours. The aim of this study was to (a) explore participants' perceptions of workplace safety; and (b) to identify the factors that impede safe behaviours by workers.

Methods

A qualitative study was conducted and reported according to analysis steps as described by Graneheim and Lundman for qualitative research. Eighteen participants were recruited using purposive and snowball sampling techniques, from petrochemical industry in Iran. Individual face-to-face semi-structured interviews were conducted to gain in-depth understanding of factors acting as a barrier for workers' safe behaviours and transcribed in Persian and then translated into English. Conventional content analysis was performed.

Results

Main themes emerging from the interviews were: (i) poor direct safety management and supervision; (ii) unsafe workplace conditions; (iii) workers' perceptions, skills and training; and (iv) broader organisational factors. They give insights into the effective measures which managers can implement to improve safe behaviours.

Discussion

These measures can eliminate the risk of work accidents and improve safety in other parts of the world where these are issues for workers.

Keywords

Unsafe behaviours, Workplace safety, Petrochemical industry, Workers